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VOORA VENTURES

Wish lists from RWAs to political parties



K Dayanand of Chitlapakkam Rising presents a wish list to Tamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam functionaries; and (above) office bearers of Federation of Nanganallur Residents Welfare Association at the DMK headquarters.

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Ahead of the polls, political parties have been knocking on the doors of residents' welfare associations in the suburbs to hear their grievances and wish list.

The AIADMK election manifesto preparation committee and Thamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam invited Chitlapakkam residents to share their requirements. Likewise, the Federation of Thiruneermalai Residents' Welfare Associations' met with Thamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam functionaries in Chengalpattu district and submitted their demands. A copy was also submitted to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) at the party's headquarters, Anna Arivalayam.

Here are some of the demands



Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar West Residents Welfare Association

- * Formulate a mechanism to prevent people dumping trash and construction debris in vacant plots
- * Roll back property tax tariff and correction of anomalies
- * Roll back hike in electricity consumption charges
- * Cut-and-cover channel at Nazeeb Avenue and Abraham Lincoln Street to prevent flooding
- * Create a new district, Tambaram
- * Allot space for parking vehicles on the eastern side of Tambaram Sanatorium railway station. Currently commuters park vehicles on Chitlapakkam Second Main Road.

Federation of Nanganallur Residents Welfare Association

- * Restore Adambakkam Lake
- * Create a dedicated parking facility for pilgrims visiting the Anjaneyar temple

Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents' Welfare Association, Chitlapakkam

- * Share auto services between Tambaram Sanatorium railway station and Babu Street in Chitlapakkam should be resumed
- * Restore Sembakkam Lake to enhance rainwater storage and create a forest with massive tree planting on all four bunds

Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Welfare Association

- * Construct roundtana at Chitlapakkam Varadharaja Theatre Junction.
- * Currently, EB reading is taken once every two months with a subsidy of 500 units. It should be done monthly, offering a subsidy of 350 units

Federation of Thiruneermalai Residents' Welfare Association

- * Overhead power cables should be routed underground.

Chitlapakkam Rising

- * Water treatment plant at Tambaram City Municipal Corporation with a capacity of 150 million litres per day
- * Extension of the metro rail network from Tirusulam to Kilambakkam and from Tambaram to Guindy
- * Ply small buses from Chitlapakkam, Sembakkam and Madambakkam regions to Chennai International Airport
- * Introduce Vande Bharat Express train from Tambaram to Tiruchendur
- * Appoint more doctors and nurses in Tambaram Sanatorium Government Hospital and convert it into a multi-speciality hospital

Federation of Senior Citizens' Associations of Tamil Nadu.

- * Old age pension should be increased to ₹5000
- * Establish a geriatric ward in all government hospitals
- * Special disciplines such as mental welfare, prevention of diseases, dementia clinics, and a rehabilitation centre for differently-abled seniors in urban and rural areas.
- * Form a self-help groups for senior citizens
- * Establish an old age home in one district headquarters and establish standard operating procedures for old age homes and train caregivers

Gated communities present key concerns

Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations organises a meeting with representatives of political parties

The Federation of Radial Road Residents' Associations (FORRR), representing 15 gated communities and several thousand families along Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Radial Road, has submitted a memorandum of issues to senior AIADMK leader and Chennai Suburban District Secretary K. P. Kandan, in view of the upcoming elections.

Over 50 residents representing multiple apartment communities along Radial Road participated in



the meeting held in one of the gated communities and voiced views on infrastructure challenges, safety concerns and other pressing matters impacting daily life with Kandhan, said a release.

The AIADMK leader heard all the concerns that were presented and assured the residents that ap-

propriate action would be initiated to address them in a time-bound manner. S. Viswanathan, AIADMK's St Thomas Mount North Union Secretary, also took part in the meeting with residents.

Office-bearers of FORRR also met Sholinganallur MLA S. Ara-

vind Ramesh and presented their memorandum of issues at an event organised under the leadership of MP S. Jagathrakshakan in Neelankarai.

The comprehensive memorandum prepared by FORRR outlined several civic concerns affecting residents and sought

FORRR office bearers submitting a memorandum to AIADMK leader K. P. Kandan along with other residents. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

commitments for their resolution in a time-bound manner. Home to thousands of working professionals, senior citizens and school children, the arterial road has witnessed rapid residential growth without commensurate infrastructure development in the last few years.

FORRR in a press release stated the initiative was undertaken ahead of the upcoming Assembly election in the larger interest of the entire Radial Road community, with the objective of ensuring coordinated efforts towards long-term solutions and improved civic amenities for all residents.



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This one for *grandpa*

At Oviya Sangamam 2026, a stall by a young resident of Rajakilpakkam showcased coconut shell-based creations by her 88-year-old grandfather

LIFY THOMAS

Not all art and craft works displayed at the recently concluded Oviya Sangamam 2026, organised by Indian Art Factory, were for sale. For some like 88-year-old Sangiah S, it was a platform to show the community of art enthusiasts that it is never too late to take up a hobby. The former vessel merchant from Dindigul creates art from coconut shells, a pastime he discovered three years ago.

He had signed up for the exhibition to display his collection and hear directly from the art community. Unfortunately, he suffered a stroke during the fag end of December and has been bedridden since then.

Sangiah's granddaughter Rishika S., a software professional, decided to fulfil his wish by showcas-



ing the works at the event held at St George School Grounds in Poonamallee.

"I had taken some videos of what visitors to the event had to say about *tatha*'s works and we were happy it



Sangiah S and Rishika; and some of his creations



acades. Nothing is wasted at the house as Sangiah picks them to make aesthetic-looking showpieces. The tripod stand at the home is made from the handle of big shopper bags, the hard surface of the table calendar is upcycled

into a mirror and a soap bar has morphed into a standing woman.

When Rishika was in school, it was grandpa who helped complete many of her best projects.

"The ideas for many of these have come from mom but the complete soul behind these works is *tatha*, he can work hours together till he gets the perfect shape," she says.

The senior citizen's recovery has been slow; in the meantime, Rishika plans to start a page on Instagram to showcase his many works. "I should have done this earlier. This is the least I can do to promote the creative ideas with the humble coconut," she adds.

Ideas to deal with a commuting crisis

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Many groups have urged the Chennai Division of the Southern Railway to swiftly address disruptions to the suburban train services on account of the redevelopment work at Chennai Egmore railway station.

As part of the reconstruction of suburban train platforms 10 and 11 and foundation work for a new roof over the platforms, train services have been disrupted since February 20.

In a letter to the Southern Railway, T. Nagar Residents' Welfare Association has asked whether Egmore station can be skipped and the usual services operated.

It has urged railway authorities to reassess the present operational plan and evolve alternative arrangements that protect the interests of the larger commuting public while redevelopment works continue.

V. Rama Rao, director, Traffic and Transportation Forum, has written to Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union Minister for Railways, stating that the State's fleet of buses is not enough to meet the regular demand of commuters, and therefore the disruption in



train services cannot be borne. The railway ministry should hire many buses on a temporary basis and operate them at a fare of ₹ 10 till the work is completed, says Rama Rao.

At present, special buses from Tambaram to Chennai Beach and vice versa run during rush hour in the morning and evening.

"There should be coordination among the railway, Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority, the Metropolitan Transport Corporation and Chennai Metro Rail to ensure

seamless commuter support during the transition period.

P. Sathyanarayanan, social activist and a long-time resident of Guindy, is of the opinion that long-distance trains operated from Chennai Egmore should be operated from Tambaram till the redevelopment work at the suburban train platforms gets completed.

"The Vande Bharat Express running from Egmore to Nagercoil should run from Egmore, as it departs at 5 a.m., and in the return direction reaches Egmore at 23.05 p.m," says

At Tambaram railway station.
PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Sathyanarayanan.

At present, shuttle services are operated between Chennai Beach and Egmore, and from Egmore to Tambaram and Chengalpattu on express train lines till Chetpet railway station, where it joins the suburban line.

"If long-distance trains are operated from Tambaram, two trains, Egmore to Tambaram and Chengalpattu, and from Chengalpattu and Tambaram to Egmore, the trains can be operated. This move will not increase commuters' traffic waiting for trains. This move will help save time and reduce crowding in other public transport, he pointed out.

"For example, if a commuter has to go from Egmore to Guindy, has to take a bus to Anna Salai and board another to Guindy. The other option is to board a metro train at Egmore, detrain at Alandur, interchange, and entrain the line (train) towards WIMCO Nagar," he added.

The air conditioners on Metro trains are ineffective due to the crowd.

Chromepet Rail Users' Forum hold protest

On February 21, members of the Chromepet Rail Users' Forum, led by its founder and president, V. Santhanam, held a protest condemning Southern Railway for cancelling 44 suburban train services due to maintenance work at Chennai Egmore railway station. It was held outside the regional railway station along GST Road.

At the protest, the forum members pointed out that the railways have not made any alternative arrangements to ease the problems faced by commuters.

Additional trains

The Southern Railway has started operating 20 additional fast electric multiple units (EMUs) between Chennai Beach and Tambaram, with limited stoppages at Mambalam, Guindy, and Chennai Egmore, and special buses from Tambaram to Chennai Beach and vice versa during rush hour.

The special bus services are provided exclusively for commuters holding valid EMU journey tickets and season tickets, ensuring that regular suburban commuters can continue their travel without disruption during peak hours, said a release.

Even as Wels in Austria hosted World Sustainable Energy Days 2026 from February 24 to 27, *The Hindu Downtown* picked the brains of quiet influencers Bhuvana Raj from Thalambur and Saravanan Palanichami from Kovilambakkam whose philosophy of sustainable energy use in their home settings is rubbing off on neighbours and friends

Infectious energy



Saravanan Palanichami and Bhuvana Raj with their respective solar installations. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

There is a pleasant monotony to how Bhuvana Raj's electricity bill reads for most part of the year. For nearly ten months annually, every billing cycle, the needle stays at zero (discounting the small regular fee).

A sustainability practitioner and zero waste consultant, Bhuvana installed a rooftop solar system at her home in Thalambur, off OMR, in 2018, when residential solar adoption in Chennai Metropolitan Area was yet to shine brightly.

Although the initial estimate suggested a 2 kW system would suffice, the family chose to plan ahead. "The estimate given for our house was 2 kW. But we decided to add one more unit, thinking that our consumption would increase in the future and we should be able to offset that as well. So we went in for a 3 kW system in 2018 itself," she says. The system cost about ₹1.5 lakh after subsidy.

"I am not exactly sure when it broke even, but I think it was

around four years after installation," she adds.

Only during peak summer, when air conditioner use increases, does the family pay anything at all. "Only during April and May, when consumption increases because of AC usage, do we pay an amount for consumption." And this amount is still one of ridiculously small numbers.

"Recently, they started charging a network fee of around ₹300 plus, so that is the only regular fee we are paying now," she explains. "Not worrying about electricity bills, especially when others pay ₹10,000 or ₹12,000 during summer, is very reassuring," she says.

Though her overall experience is pleasant, Bhuvana would like to see some wrinkles ironed out, not on her end, but Tangedco's.

"When we generate more energy than we use, it goes back to the grid, but Tangedco does not pay us for that surplus. Besides, there is no dashboard to show how many unused units we are giving back," she says.

She adds that people often have doubts when choosing systems. Off

grid systems use batteries and can function during outages. Systems connected to the grid are more economical but shut down during power cuts for safety reasons. "Our area gets flooded during monsoons, and sometimes power cuts continue for days. In such situations, off grid systems help. But when we did the math, on grid made more sense economically in the long run," she says.

In her gated villa community of around 330 houses, rooftop solar adoption has steadily increased. "Around 30 to 40 per cent have gone solar. We are not actively promoting it, but people are installing it on their own after understanding the benefits" she says.

For Bhuvana, the decision goes beyond savings. "I see solar not just as a cost saving option but also as a responsible choice for the future. In our country, we have abundant sunlight almost throughout the year," she says.

She also believes more attention must be paid to what happens later. "After 20 or 30 years, what happens to these panels? How will they be recycled? These are areas

where more research is needed," she says, adding that policy and research must evolve alongside adoption.

A smart move

A software engineer based in Kovilambakkam, Saravanan Palanichami installed his first solar system 13 years ago, at the time he built his house. "The original idea was to ensure uninterrupted power supply," he says. Instead of depending entirely on an inverter connected to the grid, he chose a 1.4 kilowatt off grid system with batteries that could function like a UPS.

For years, that system powered the essentials – fans, refrigerator, televisions, computers and lights. During the day, solar panels charged the batteries. At night, the stored energy ran the house until early morning. When Cyclone Vardah struck Chennai and power cuts lasted for days, his decision proved wise. "During major storms in Chennai, including Cyclone Vardah, when there were week long power cuts, this system proved extremely useful," he recalls.

But the real turning point came recently, with the purchase of an electric vehicle.

"Recently, we bought an electric vehicle. We realised that if the car had to be truly zero emission, the energy used to charge it should also come from renewable sources," he says. That realisation prompted the installation of an additional 6 kilowatt on grid solar system.

Unlike the battery backed setup, the on grid system operates independently of household wiring. "The on grid system is not connected to any of my appliances, including the EV. It supplies power back to the grid through the power lines," he explains. Through net metering, electricity generated during the day is exported to the grid.

His advice to EV owners: "If you have an on grid system, you are already prepared. Try to charge your EV during the day to maximise the use of your generated power. If you have to charge at night, your solar installation will still reduce your overall electricity cost, but you will not be reducing the load on the grid at that time."

It was raining drones



Students showcased their prowess at the national-level drone challenge organised by KCG College of Technology

A student is working on a flight at the drone challenge.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Eighty-five teams from across the country showcased advanced unmanned aerial systems at the Drone Development Challenge (DDC) 2026 hosted by KCG College of Technology.

Organised by the Society of Automotive Engineers India - Southern Section (SAEISS) and the Department of Aeronautical and Aerospace Engineering, the national-level competition brought together engineering students to design, fabricate, and demonstrate fully functional drones.

The challenge followed a rig-

orous three-stage evaluation model designed to mirror real-world aerospace assessment frameworks, said a release.

On day 1, participating teams submitted detailed technical design reports covering aerodynamic calculations, propulsion architecture, structural configuration, and mission strategy before an expert panel. This was followed by a thorough physical inspection of the drone systems to verify build quality, compliance, and engineering accuracy. On days 2 and 3, teams conducted live flight demonstrations, testing drones under monitored

conditions for endurance, maneuverability, stability, payload handling, and mission completion accuracy. The structured evaluation ensured that students were assessed not only on design concepts but also on execution, reliability, and operational performance.

A release stated that the challenge was designed to simulate industry-standard validation processes, preparing students for careers in aerospace manufacturing, drone services, and defence technology. The farewell ceremony recognised the winners for their exceptional technical innovation.

Student of SRM selected as Google Ambassdor

Ramprakash R. is among only six students in India to be given this title and an opportunity to meet Google CEO Sundar Pichai



Ramprakash R., a final year B.Tech CSE (AIML) student from the Department of Computer Science and Engineering (Emerging Technologies), SRM Institute of Science and Technology in Vadapalani, has earned national recognition as one of six Google Student Ambassadors across India.

According to a press release, Ramprakash received the extraordinary opportunity to directly interact with

Sundar Pichai, CEO of Google, during the India AI Impact Summit 2026 held on February 18, 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi.

At the summit, he contributed to discussions on Responsible and Inclusive AI, bridging academia and industry, and empowering engineering students through applied AI. The achievement highlights his technical excellence and brings pride and national recognition to SRM IST, the release adds.

School shines in STEM

Students of Shri Natesan Vidyasala Matriculation Higher Secondary School in Mannivakkam came runner-up in the prestigious global 'STEM' competition by Formula 1.

Among 120 schools nationwide, the school team stood out for its creativity, collaboration, and curiosity, earning praise from British delegates who interacted with the students, listened to their ideas and appreciated their efforts, said a release.

The school's STEM lab has four achievements under its belt. Participating in a global STEM competition, collaborating with a UK school to work on real-world projects, designing innovative solutions for challenges faced both locally and by their partner school, and showcasing their learning before a larger international audience, added the release.

Scholars honoured

Shriram Bharathi Kalai Ilakkiya Kazhagam recently observed the 144th birth anniversary of freedom fighter and poet Subramania Bharathi at Krishna Gana Sabha, T. Nagar. Three eminent scholars promoting Bharathi's work across the globe, M. Thyagarajan, Kalaimamani Keezhambur Sankara Subramanian, and V.G. Booma, were felicitated on the occasion with cash awards and citations. Ku. Gnanasambanthan, emeritus, professor Thiagarajar College, Madurai, spoke on 'Vetri Mael Vetri'. Justice R. Suresh Kumar, Madras High Court, released a book, 'Avvaiyin Senthamizh Puthaiyal.'

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A mixed party of migratory ducks at the salterns in Nemmeli



▼ If one looked at the ducks swimming in the waters in the picture above, they would realise what the hazy mass of colours on the bund represent: Eurasian wigeon, Garganey and Northern shoveler. In the picture below, the Northern shoveler and the Eurasian wigeon are in huge numbers, and the former is the foreground and seems to be in bold relief. A glimpse of a mixed party of migratory ducks at the salterns off the Nemmeli-Thiruporur Link Road (connecting East Coast Road and Old Mahabalipuram Road) on February 22, 2026. PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK



Rumblers needed at intersections in Nanganallur



Motorists negotiating three intersections in Nanganallur have requested Zone 12 (Alandur) of the Greater Chennai Corporation to install rumblers.

The three intersections are First and Second Main Road, Sixth Main Road, Macmillan Colony, and Nanganallur 23rd Street, and Fourth Main Road, Sixth Main Road, and 46th Street.

The speed calming measures on Second Main Road are not designed scientifically and

do not help the road users.

"It is difficult to cross as motorists come from all directions at a clip," complained A Rajesh, a resident of Nanganallur.

The speed breakers on Fourth Main Road and Sixth Main Road are beset with the same problem.

Residents want rumblers to be installed, and until then, the intersections must be manned by traffic police during rush hour.

Text: T.S. Atul Swaminathan

Thriller comedy in Chromepet

The Chromepet Cultural Academy is hosting Y. Gee. Mahendra's United Amateur Artists 'Lights On', a thriller comedy on March 1 at the Academy hall at 6:30 p.m.

For details, contact G. Nagarajan, secretary, Chromepet Cultural Academy, at 94446 90174.

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